

Interview Transcript – Participant O

Study: Early Value Challenges for Non-Technical Users of AI Automation Builders

Date: 18 March 2026

Duration: ~30 minutes

Interviewer: J (researcher)

Participant: O (pseudonym)

Participant Role: Product Manager based in Europe, with a background in software engineering prior to completing an MBA at a German university. Currently working in product management with day-to-day responsibilities spanning stakeholder communication, user research, and product development. Has prior hands-on experience automating workflows using no-code and AI-based automation tools in a professional context.

Anonymization note: All identifying information (name, specific employer names, university names) has been removed or replaced with neutral descriptors.

J: All right, yeah, so could you briefly describe what you do, who you are, what your day-to-day responsibilities are?

O: Yes, sure. So I've been based in India and I have been a software engineer before my MBA, and I've done my MBA from a university in Germany. Then I worked as a product manager and currently I am also working as a product manager. My day-to-day activities are related to researching about a particular product or what we are trying to launch. Also my day-to-day responsibilities are to talk with our stakeholders and also connecting our team with the end users.

J: Okay, nice. And how would you describe your technical background? Do you have any experience with programming or building things digitally?

O: Yeah, so in my past role I worked in automating workflows and we have used a different number of tools like Zapier, Make, and Airtable, and also we have used newer tools which are LLM-based, like writing the prompt and getting the work done — getting a front page or home page and that kind of stuff. Also I have made different types of profiles or websites by using these kinds of new LLM tools.

J: Okay, cool. Yeah, so you already mentioned Zapier and Airtable, right? Are those the only two automation tools you have used, or other ones as well?

O: Yes, I have used other ones as well. I've used Zapier, Airtable, Make, and another automation platform.

J: Nice, yeah. Those are the main ones as well, I think the most popular ones. Yeah, okay, cool. Yeah, so what were you actually trying to accomplish when you first started using an automation tool? Could you think of an example of what you wanted to automate for example, or what goal you wanted to achieve?

O: Yeah, so in my past role, we were actually building a platform to connect two main stakeholders. So the first part what we were trying to do was to onboard both of the stakeholders — so the onboarding part towards our application was being automated. For that we actually used Zapier and Airtable. Zapier we used for automating the workflow and Airtable we used for getting the database ready for our users. So the main part was to get the user onboarded towards our platform, getting

the details of them, what are their likings and what are their preferences, and merging them in Airtable and categorizing them in a manner so that we could also get an idea of what we have to give them in our website.

J: Okay, and in your own words, what would success have looked like when you started using it in the first session? So what would you have wanted to achieve the first time that you started using it?

O: Yeah, so as I mentioned, I already used it before, so it was quite easy for me. But if I would have not been a core user of AI automation or AI tools, I would have definitely faced a lot of problems. Initially, when I was also learning and not yet building automations, I didn't have abstract knowledge of the core concepts like triggers, actions, webhooks, or what APIs are. So initially I had to understand those critical concepts before building the actual automation. Learning those things was pretty much intimidating for me. But once I got the hang of all these concepts, and once the easier workflows started getting completed and working properly, then we decided to make a proper workflow and automation and integrate them with our website. So initially, it was frustrating — getting errors, not getting the workflow completed. But yeah, in around one or two weeks, we got to the point of what we wanted.

J: Okay, yeah. Because how long did it take you to learn those concepts that you had to understand first before you actually could do something? How long did it take to learn those most essential concepts?

O: Yeah, so it was around one to two weeks that it would have taken us to learn the core concepts. As I mentioned, there are like three main parts when doing an automation. First would be the trigger — on which trigger our workflow should start. Second would be the action from that trigger. For a non-technical user, they should also first understand what the whole process actually is. For example, when we check our email, we have to open our browser or Gmail app, then we look for new emails, we find the email we are looking for, we search them in the search box, then we see the results, and then we click on the one we are looking for, and then we respond to that particular email. This is a particular path which we follow for replying to any email. A non-technical user has to understand there are multiple things going on. Then one should also have an understanding of trigger points, and then what actions they have to take. Suppose we got an email for this meeting — one has to take an action, like confirm that meeting by replying to the email, or we could also automate that: if we get an email about any research or thesis-related thing, we could reply in a particular manner.

J: Yeah, okay. And before you opened the automation tool for the first time, what did you really expect of that first session?

O: I mean, there was not much expectation from my end when I first started with it. Back then, I think I started around early 2024. Initially, I thought it would be a very easy thing to do. While starting it, there were a lot of things to understand first, and then making a general shift to understand each concept, and then applying those concepts into a particular tool, and then doing the whole process. So there was a learning curve of around two weeks initially, and understanding that there are a lot of possibilities that can be done. I think right now, things have immensely increased — there are approximately 7,000 apps which are connected in some of these platforms. And I believe there is nothing which we cannot do right now. But we have to understand what the core things we want to do are. So there is a learning curve, and we have to get our hands on it to get the things done.

J: Yeah, okay. Yeah, so now I also really want you to think back to your first session, maybe also if you started using an AI automation builder. So if you think back to that, could you walk me through what happened step by step? So trying to get started?

O: Sure. So if I take you back to my first session on one of the platforms, I actually watched a couple of videos to learn the things — that really helped. But most importantly, the thing which helped me was the original tutorial which they have on the website. So nowadays, each and every app has guidance on how to use a particular button or functionality. I had an opportunity to see that first. And they help us in the app itself — they help us make our first automation, which is quite simple and doable, and which gets the thing done, and which gives confidence to the user. So that was the first thing. And with that, I actually saw different components which can be used for upcoming automations — the triggers, like a chat trigger or a new email coming into Gmail as another trigger. Second were the actions which we could take — for example, once we get an email, the action we can take is to send a message to a particular user in Slack or to send a message to a particular group in Slack.

J: Yeah. And I'm also especially interested in moments where something didn't go the way you expected. So were there some moments like that?

O: Yeah, there are a lot of moments where things didn't go well. So initially, there are a lot of confusions while building AI automation. When we were assigning different AI models into the LLMs, we had to set a different type of parameters. Also, the type of prompting which we have to give should be very particular. And sometimes we don't get the exact answers which we are actually looking for. So we have to set things like temperature for getting an exact type of answer. So things go wrong there. Secondly, there are technical problems related to data mapping. While we were doing the onboarding of our users for the platform using Airtable, it was actually having a lot of fields and variables which had to be assigned by automation only. So this had a big impact and it took a lot of time while assigning each data field with automation.

J: So with the use of LLMs, sometimes I could imagine that you don't really understand the output of a system. So when an automation gave you an output or a result, did you always know how it got there?

O: Yeah, I mean, sometimes we do understand how it is happening, but sometimes we don't. And there are things where sometimes we should just let the LLM do its thing, and we should not focus more on how it is doing it, but we should focus on: is it giving the correct output or not? Is it giving the exact result? So once there was a time that we were stuck and we just watched a YouTube video for solving a particular problem. We got an exact video on YouTube for the AI tool to do it, and we just copy-pasted all the things which were shown, and we let the AI automation do the thing, and we didn't spend much effort on understanding it, and just got the result.

J: Okay, yeah, nice. Is there anything the tool showed you that really helped you, or some things that made it more confusing? Could you think of examples?

O: Yeah, I mean, initially, once the user is very new or hasn't had their hands on any particular tool, there would be a lot of confusion. We also had this confusion during onboarding or doing the Airtable configuration. But there's always an upside and downside of using a particular tool, because nowadays tools are changing so frequently. There can be things which can be done easily on a particular tool — suppose one platform does a particular job better, but another has the same task in

a very much simpler and easier UI manner. So there are priorities which have to be decided for a particular user based on what they actually want to do. It basically boils down to the particular user who is trying to solve the problem in an effective manner.

J: Yeah, okay. And about trust and control — did you always feel in control of what was happening with your automations, or were you sometimes handing things over without really knowing what would happen?

O: Yeah, so there were some concerns from my team that we should always have a policy that while using an LLM or AI automation, we should be compliant to the different type of regulations. And also, we should train our model in a manner that it makes the process smoother. And yeah, we were actually aware of what the automation was actually doing. We also had a person who was specifically responsible for monitoring the type of output or result which it gives.

J: Yeah, okay. So most of the time you felt in control because you really understood what you built and the automations that you built. Let me see. Yeah, so if you sometimes got stuck during building an automation, how did you try to get unstuck? Did you use documentation, YouTube tutorials, trial and error — what was your main go-to?

O: Yeah, so the best first step for any stuck place is to get to the documentation. But as you know, documentation is very niche and for a new user or non-technical user, it can be a difficult task to understand. But we often tried to understand the documentation and follow the particular path or process which it describes. Also, nowadays there are search functionalities inside the AI tools — we could directly search and state the problem we are facing and then it explains from the documentation. So this is the go-to thing we follow now. The second part would be YouTube tutorials from different channels. And I think these two are the main debugging processes we follow.

J: Yeah, okay. Yeah, so at the end of that very first session that you started using an AI automation tool, did you already feel like you had accomplished something useful?

O: Yeah, I mean, when we actually start learning or do our first automation, it gives us a lot of confidence and it feels that we have achieved a lot. But in reality, we have actually done a very small automation. But yeah, it gives us a feeling of accomplishment initially, because that is a very small AI automation. But when it comes to doing very complex things, it takes a lot of time, practice, and understanding of different systems. In reality, it takes a longer time to accomplish the bigger things.

J: Yeah, I could imagine. Yeah, so if the automation tool could have done one thing differently to make its first experience better, do you have any ideas for what that would be?

O: It's a good question. Yeah, as I mentioned, the in-house tutorial videos or tutorial sections for each component — if that can be enhanced or made more simple and understandable, that would be the best thing for any particular tool. And with that, they can give particular examples for getting started for a new user. That would be the best part which they can improve.

J: Yeah, okay. Yeah, so that's the main thing that they could improve — the tutorials and the in-house videos. Yeah, clear. Yeah, so that first experience, did that change how willing you are to automate other things in your work? Because you said you kind of got a quick first win because you automated something simple, and then it felt pretty good. Did that change anything in how willing you are to try automating other things?

O: Yes, exactly. I mean, as I said, when it gives the feeling of a quick win, it boosts the confidence of the user. And yeah, there are more chances that the user would be likely to learn things from that particular app which made them do the first automation. And there would be more liking towards that particular app which helped them make the first AI automation.

J: Yeah, okay, cool. Yeah, I think I've asked almost everything that I wanted to know. Is there anything else that comes to mind that you want to add to this interview?

O: Yeah, sure. So I mean, as I understand, AI automation has been happening from the past three to four years, but I believe one should be open to learning different types of automation tools, because one should not be dependent on a single particular tool. Since the market is very evolving, we should understand the core concepts of how things are working, but not totally focusing on a particular tool or particular type of work. And we should be open to learning the new concepts which are getting introduced. And yeah, I think we should always be open to learning and fine-tuning ourselves in terms of AI and automation.

J: Okay, nice addition. Do you also have any questions for me?

O: Yeah, I have just a few questions. What was your motivation to do this particular research and how did it get started?

J: Good question. Yeah, so during my master's, I also started a startup with two friends. And with that startup, we actually had the idea in the beginning to build an automation platform ourselves. So we wanted to create a platform where you could describe in natural language what you want to automate, and then our AI would build the automation. So that's what we wanted to build ourselves. And then, yeah, I found a thesis supervisor who also said that you could do a topic related to that. And I myself am also always really interested in user experience and trying... [recording ends]